

Digital Perspectives on Corelli's Trio Sonatas

Abstract

This presentation introduces a digital research and teaching platform developed within the seminar “Digital Methods for the Analysis of Corelli's Trio Sonatas” at the University of Music Freiburg during the winter semester 2025/26. The project combines analytical approaches with digital tools to make structural and stylistic features of Corelli's trio sonatas directly accessible within the musical score.

The platform renders key music-theoretical concepts – such as cadences, sequences (“Satzmodelle”), and tonal areas – explorable within an interactive environment. These features are based on manually created annotations. Users can search for these phenomena across the entire corpus and visually highlight them in the score, enabling an exploratory and practice-oriented approach to analysis.

A central aim of the project is pedagogical. It supports students working with Baroque music and historical compositional techniques by providing a framework for targeted inquiry. Students can further develop their own compositions by directly comparing specific musical phenomena with corresponding passages in Corelli's works. In addition, broader corpus-wide statistical analyses allow these observations to be contextualized and verified. For example, recurring patterns such as descending and ascending syncopation chains can be examined in their contrapuntal and harmonic context. This makes it possible to understand how such patterns work within Corelli's compositional language and how they contribute to a larger formal structure.

Overall, the interactive platform demonstrates how digital tools can extend traditional music theory by making analytical structures visible and usable within the composition itself, opening further perspectives for theoretical and musicological research on certain Baroque repertoire.

Bio

Wolfgang Drescher (born 1991 in Basel) completed a master's degree in music theory with Prof. Dr. Felix Diergarten at the Freiburg University of Music in 2018. From 2018–2021 he worked as a programmer and project manager at jkweb in Basel and Zurich. After teaching as a lecturer at the Freiburg University of Music, he became professor of music theory with a focus on digital media at the same university in 2021. His research develops computational tools for music theory. He contributes to open-source projects including Verovio and Humdrum and co-developed “Singing upon the (Note-)book” (contrapunto.ch).